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Lanre Olagoke



In Lanre's words: "When I paint it creates an environment that welcomes everybody in, many people have seen my work whether African or European it's for everybody. I put passion into it and I derive so many things from so many countries, places and cultures. For me personally art doesn't stop in painting alone, music, colours, sounds, visuals and things that we see all the time are also my influences. I am so particular with detail, art is my salvation - this is what I know, it is the key to my being. I love colours, I live colours, I breathe colours. I am grateful for the children of this new generation, they say good parents leave an inheritance for their children's children and that is why I am so passionate about youth. Sometimes it's

not only our own children, we are talking about nations and youth in general and I hope they actually find hope in my work. I hope they find peace in my work, and I hope they find beauty in my work.

Interestingly, it's appointed for man to die one day so we are all going to die one day, but if I die, what legacy am I leaving behind? That's always the question for me, I am not going to be here forever. My prayer is to live a long life, to fulfil my purpose and to leave a legacy for my children's children to come. And what legacy? I will always go back to hope, that people can find hope and not give up as my heart is in people. If people remember Lanre I want them to remember that yes I took something from him which is hope - To me, with this, my work is finished."

Below, Green Peace;
bottom, Atmosphere.





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WELCOME



Whilst on my travels in pursuit of all things luxurious from an African perspective a question has emerged. Where on earth has Africa not influenced? As you ponder this I am sure many will agree that Africa has influenced the entire planet. (In what way? Played a defining cultural role? Economic?)

With this in mind it's no surprise that in this edition of the magazine, we have a truly colourful mix of articles from around the world, all containing a little something special relating to Africa.

This issue focuses largely on the Arts, as African Art has continued to raise its profile outside of the

continent, with record prices reached and no signs of the market slowing down.

As Barrack and Michelle Obama exit the White House, the new administration settles in, and the United Kingdom plans its exit from the European Union, we can now see that the Western world has moved into a time of uncertainty. The Eastern countries, once considered third world, have begun to show increasingly positive signs that signal incredible growth and development.

It seems that the global tide has begun a seismic shift and the paradigms within the minds of many have created measurable changes resulting in an awakening that will shape a new world of untapped possibility with Africa at the epicentre.

Joseph Farodoye
Chief Thinker

THE COLLECTIVE

Joseph S Farodoye
Founder

Uyai Akpan
Head of Operations

Kemi Sulu
Head of Finance

Mehetabel Merid
Deputy Editor

Dean Christmas
Senior Designer

Andrae Palmer
Brand Consultant

Fabien Soazandry
VFX Artist

Anthonia Agbelusi
International Liaison (Spain)

Paola Audrey Ndengue
International Liaison (Paris)

Publisher
Africa Property Invest (API)

Printing & Finishing
Neptune Design

Contributors
General Yakubu Gowon
Denice Refael
Laure Olagoke
Jeff Barnes
Tina Lobondi

Interviews
Deborah Meaden
Philip Telesford
Simone Cipriani
Lauren Von Der Pool
John Tabatabai
Hanneli Rupert
Maria Pajares

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Welcome to the Estate Property Guide, the authority on property, lifestyle and all things luxury across Africa

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PROPERTY



BASIC GUIDE TO INVESTING IN AFRICA

By Joseph Farodoye

Why investing in property within Africa could be one of the most important things you do. Some people have a tendency to make things complicated and property investment is one of those terms which sound more complicated than it actually is. The definition of investment is the action or process of investing money for profit, and I believe it is that simple.



No matter who you are or where you reside the basic fundamentals to property investing in Africa are the same. Here is a quick checklist to help you on your way.

1. Establish a reason for investing - This will keep you focused and help to define your investment parameters and goals.
2. Your financial budget must be established - If you are looking at raising additional capital through borrowing, make sure you get more than one professional opinion. Factor every additional cost so that you understand what the potential ROI (Return on Investment) may be.



3. Due diligence is crucial - Having overall knowledge of the country, state, region, town or road you are investing in will make a big difference if you understand what you are looking for! However, one of the most important elements within your due diligence process is local knowledge. This can be the difference between making a good property investment and making a great property investment, the kind that will yield great profits from the point of acquisition. You can acquire this knowledge through speaking to someone on the ground in the area you are considering, who may be able to give you an unbiased overview of the location. They may just offer an unsuspected morsel of information that could make all the difference.

4. Your exit strategy is paramount - When looking at investing in property within Africa this is often overlooked. But if something went wrong how quickly could you either dispose of the asset or withdraw your investment and repatriate your

funds? This can be a potential minefield as there are so many factors to consider, but when conducting your research in this area it is advisable to get as much professional advice from local businesses as you can.

5. Set a realistic time frame for your acquisition - Make sure you take the time to go and visit the area you are interested in. In many cases, some people have sat in the comfort of their own environment and sent others to look on their behalf, but honestly there is nothing like the satisfaction of knowing for yourself. This helps to eradicate any doubts you may have and reinforces any decisions you may make.



All of these points are important when considering any type of property investment and are even more crucial when looking in Africa. For me investing in Africa has been an eye-opening experience, as it has allowed me to begin understanding the different issues associated with the varying investment climates that exist in every region of every country within Africa. Problems exist everywhere in the world, so it's important that you understand the unique problems associated with where you are looking to invest and factor them in to your equation. The opportunities I have encountered in Africa have been so vast that it's often hard to comprehend, but before you rush to jump on the first plane and invest, understand there are sometimes limited resources which can make your investment goals even more difficult to achieve. However, when I look back and consider all that I have done I have no regrets. I now understand that investing in Africa has been one of my most important and gratifying achievements, and I will continue to do so.

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HORIZONS

NEW

Building on their success on Sal Island,
The Resort Group PLC looks to Boa Vista for
the next investment opportunity





Boa Vista, the peaceful, stunning island that sits out on the edge of the archipelago of Cape Verde, has long welcomed excited visitors to its beautiful shores. A fast-emerging tourism hotspot, it has enjoyed its fair share of the over 500,000 people who chose Cape Verde as their ideal holiday destination last year. Of course, it's a stunning island to visit, surrounded by soft beaches, interesting wildlife and a vibrant culture.

Set to capitalise on this expanding market, The Resort Group PLC broke ground on White Sands Hotel & Spa on the sun-soaked shore of Santa Monica beach in December 2015. This exciting new development forms part of the Cape Verde government's ambition for major touristic development. As well as approving plans for new hotels and resorts, the government is investing in enhancing the island's infrastructure with new roads, improved power supplies and desalination plants all contributing to the drive. It fits into The Resort Group PLC's master plan for Boa Vista, which also incorporates an impressive marina, developed in partnership with some of the world's leading hotel brands. The hope is that these initiatives will transform Santa Monica into a truly desirable beach destination, whilst preserving Boa Vista's unique and unexplored edge.

The development itself, which will be made up of 835 deluxe properties, is set to be split into family and adult-only sections, ensuring that all guests enjoy the highest quality of service tailored to their individual needs. The family-orientated facilities include two separate children's pools, a baby pool and adventure playground as well as a kids club for entertainment day and night. Guests will also enjoy a wet bar and luxurious poolside restaurant, serving up first-class refreshments throughout the day.

While work continues, the Group is also looking to the future - White Sands Hotel & Spa is just the beginning. It will be one of six developments that will eventually be built on Boa Vista, seeking to replicate the success of their Resorts on Sal Island. Commenting on their renewed focus, CEO and Founder of The Resort Group PLC, Rob Jarrett said "Sal has grown up, and our successful investment model is set to be replicated in Boa Vista. Like Sal, the island will become a property investment hotspot and the reasons for this are simple. Its stunning beaches, year-round sunshine and increasing number of direct flights from across the UK and Europe will entice people looking for an alternative holiday destination."

There are a variety of properties still available to buy off plan, from premium Deluxe Suites with panoramic sea views and Deluxe Swim-Up Suites that have a private garden to stunning vistas from the Beach Front Suites and the spacious Penthouses. The full range offers a diverse selection of properties designed for all budgets and tastes.

For further information on purchasing a property at White Sands Hotel & Spa, please contact The Resort Group PLC on 01332 387811 • info@theresortgroupplc.com • www.trg-property.com

L'Amandier: A Hidden Treasure in the Atlas Mountains



Nestled in the undiscovered Atlas Mountains of Morocco, L'Amandier is a new boutique hotel and villa collection opening to guests in March 2017. Created to be among the most exceptional hotel resorts in Morocco by Anwar Harland-Khan and his brother Riaz, the exquisite L'Amandier hotel is located in prime position to enjoy 360° views over the surrounding Toubkal National Park, stunning gardens and dramatic Atlas peaks.

Set within 12 acres of citrus groves, the elegant hotel will open with just 6 suites, all of which have their own terrace and uninterrupted views of the surrounding landscape and the Ouirgane Lake in the distance. Graceful interior design by Michael Kopinski complements the natural surroundings with teal accents carried through the reception area, to the lounge, bar and restaurant with elevated terrace for al fresco entertaining. Below the terrace, the infinity pool invites guests to cool off from the Moroccan sun overlooking the striking mountains.

The retreat also offers a collection of 2 and 3 bedroom villas located adjacent to the hotel, each with its own plunge pool sunken into the outdoor terrace, as well as a private roof terrace complete with plush cabana.

Anwar explains, "At L'Amandier, we set out to create a soulful, stripped back escape, offering a peaceful haven for guests to unwind from the stress and busyness of their day to day lives. We have created an environment where guests shift from the chaos of modern living into tranquillity and calm, inspired by a simple and spiritual way of life, while maintaining the quality of a 5-star property. Every element of the hotel has been carefully chosen to reflect these values. L'Amandier offers a priceless experience where guests can embrace the tranquillity that we so rarely glimpse in our modern lives.

The hotel opens in Spring 2017, realising our vision that was greatly inspired by the stunning location, where breathtakingly beautiful nature combines with opportunities to experience adventure in the Atlas Mountains. The very soul of L'Amandier marries these two principles, with each aspect of the project designed to emphasise this: from the vibrant gardens to the playlists in the bedrooms and the thread count of the bed linens."



Having developed on only 5% of the land mass, L'Amandier was greatly inspired by the majestic surroundings of the Ouirgane Valley. Using environmentally sensitive construction and local craftspeople has made for a truly unique development befitting of and entirely attuned to its beautiful natural environment.

Beyond the region's remarkable natural beauty, it offers to visitors a myriad of activities including hiking, horse riding, and even skiing.

L'Amandier's knowledgeable in-house guide, Said, can tour guests expertly through the nearby Berber villages and striking red earth valley. Other activities available onsite include tennis and private yoga classes.

L'Amandier's vision moves away from the opulence and common trappings of 'luxury' and embraces a more peaceful existence where nature takes centre stage, and is accompanied by unforgettable quality and service.

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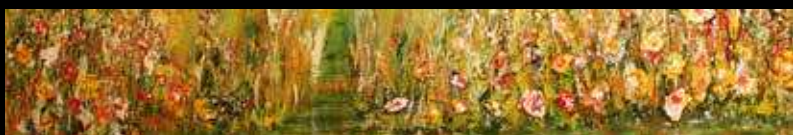
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PEOPLE





DEBORAH MEADEN

THE SUCCESSFUL UK ENTREPRENEUR AND DRAGONS' DEN INVESTOR

Interview with **Joseph Farodoye**



As a business woman a lot of your businesses have been based in Europe or the UK, what has taken you specifically to Africa?

Well, other than the fact that some of my businesses do business with Africa, I don't have any African based businesses. But my husband actually grew up in Kenya, and he had such a wonderful time in Kenya that he didn't want to go back and spoil his memories. But I am a huge animal lover, supporter and campaigner and I became involved with a charity that had several projects throughout the continent and before I get involved with any charity I always go to see what difference it is actually making on the ground. So I went over there and Paul (Deborah's husband) said "alright I'll come over again", I fell in love with Africa, he re-fell in love with Africa and we'll be off to Tanzania in a couple of weeks.

Where in Tanzania are you going?

All over! We've got friends in Dar es Salaam, so we're doing several safari tours.

Is it your first time there?

No, we had a visit to the Great Ruaha a couple of years ago for the WWF (World Wildlife Fund) and that was exciting. I've been to Tanzania so it's a return trip.

So the love affair continues with Africa?

Oh, absolutely, I mean what's not to love! Well, I'm sure there are things not to love about Africa, there's plenty not to love about a lot of the world, but there's also plenty to love.

So, what does the Deborah Meaden brand stand for?

Well I wouldn't like to think of myself as a brand. Honestly, I think of myself as a person who although I protect my good name, it really isn't a brand. I've never been paid to endorse any product at all, I only do interviews and appear on programs that I feel are valid and that I want to do. I have the luxury of not being driven by finances so I can choose to live the life that I want to live; so it isn't a brand, it's the way I am. Particularly when you have lots of people trying to make up their mind about what you are, or trying to make you into this thing, it's really important to me that I am very true to myself. I made myself promises way before I had money and way before I was famous on television. I made myself promises about the way I wanted to live. Sometimes life gets in the way of those things but I do remind myself very often of the person I want to be and therefore I measure my choices against that. I've always been not just an animal lover but I love people. Business for me is fantastic because you get to engage with all sorts of people on all sorts of levels; you really can get under the skin of your customer. When I had holiday parks, I had 150,000 people a year coming and staying with us and I loved it. But I like my customers, it's not just lip service, I like people. So honestly my worry about being referred to as a brand is as if I sat there and decided "this is how I want people to see me". I haven't but what I have decided is that I am going to be me. But I do have to know what me is and I do have to remind myself every now and then of what that is.

What are your core values?

In terms of my characteristics, I mean if you have watched Dragons' Den I'm pretty honest. I would like to be thought of as honest, fair and compassionate. I am tough but I'm certainly not hard; I would hate to think that somebody thought I was hard. I don't get laughs without having a lot of fun. Those are the things I would like someone to think about me - I'm very loyal, I would want me on my side. If you make one mistake with me, that's fine, if you make two mistakes and you do it a third time then it can be a bit like well "you've had your chances and that's it". So I don't suffer fools gladly or for long periods so those would be my characteristics. In terms of things that I care about, originally I've always cared about British wildlife; I just care about animals. It is probably better to express it as I care about people who can't take care of themselves, and not just people but things and that either is children living in tough environments or animals kept in zoos or living with cruelty. It's often caring for things that really need caring for. I think that kind of goes hand in hand with the

environmental issues because I see that as a race, all the things that we love and the beautiful things that we love, we're actually destroying. One day we will wake up and think "What have we done?" but I just think we're bright enough to avoid this rather than having to look at the consequences. So the environment has always been an issue for me.

What was the motivation behind getting involved with Tusk?

Several things, I was involved with the WWF (World Wildlife Fund) and it was through a contact there that said "I think I should introduce you to a contact of mine at Tusk". Because they (TUSK) tend to be hands on, they get things done. You know there are big issues that take years and years and years to deal with and they can be rewarding but also very frustrating because you think, "Oh we're going nowhere". But what I really liked about TUSK is that when I did visit the projects, I could see the difference they were making now, the imminent differences. And although it sounds like an animal charity nearly half of its money is spent on communities. In fact a big part of its money is spent on communities so it's "The people living alongside the animals" charity and I like that. It's a proper sustainable way of changing the way people live with their wildlife and valuing their wildlife but done in a compassionate way; not the sort of finger wagging "How dare you do this" kind of way but in a way where if you can understand the value of your wildlife, it can make your life better and I really like that.

How do you think that TUSK as a philanthropic organisation is different from some of the other organisations that you may have come across?

I think it is their direct effect - they get on with stuff. I have been involved with organisations that talk an awful lot and take an awfully long time to get stuff done. And I think that honestly TUSK operate in a very intelligent way. They fundraise in the UK and in the US but they actually use people in-country to establish the projects that they think are really going to make the biggest differences. So you know sitting over here making wise decisions on how we would do better to spend our money over in Africa, it would be a much more intelligent way to actually use people in-country. >



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When it comes to your motivation what would you say are your key drivers, what motivates you specifically?

It's easy to say it's not money when you've actually got it but in the end it was money. You know, I didn't have any (chuckles) and I wanted money and the things that money could buy, but of course now, why do I still invest in businesses, why am I still actively involved in 30 active businesses, why do I do that?

I just realised that, you know, I like doing stuff.

I'm very interested in the world, I'm interested in how business works and I'm interested in people. I'm interested in understanding how it ticks, it keeps me motivated to be watching the world and watching the markets, it's just what I love. I've been accused of being a workaholic and I go "No no no you've got this wrong completely". I can "Not work" when I don't want to work but this isn't work to me. This is stuff I really love so why wouldn't I do it? Of course I'd do it! But you know I also

like to achieve stuff and I like to make a difference.

I've realised that being able to buy expensive flash things, the things people expect me to buy, doesn't do it for me at all. What really does it for me, is when I can actually help a business move from its start-up stage to being a successful business - now that really does it for me.

Hence the reason why I really spend my time investing. I'd rather my money living out there, out in the big wide world helping businesses and growing them. For me that's incredibly motivating.

What would you like the lasting legacy for your charity to be in three words?

I'd like to see that it's not needed anymore, that would be the most important thing to me.

In terms of the geographical area that TUSK focuses on, where is that?

It's the African continent, it isn't country specific but it's project specific. So on the African continent, if there is a project that is brought to TUSK's attention and it falls within tusks specific remit and criteria then TUSK will work with it. There's quite a lot of work in Kenya, Botswana, Namibia and Zambia so pretty much around the continent.

Could you describe the feeling that you get when you see the results paying off within the charity work that you're doing with TUSK?

I don't think there's anything quite like it because it's more meaningful than a lot of the things I've achieved in life. Some have got legacy and some are just momentary - but that is about as meaningful as it gets. Because it's all very well talking about issues but actually seeing that people are in there, changing lives and properly conserving wildlife communities its...its...the best feeling.

Excerpt from the keynote address by

HIS EXCELLENCY GENERAL (DR) YAKUBU GOWON



REVISIT THE PAST, CONSOLIDATE THE PRESENT, BUILD THE FUTURE

The theme of this Fellows' Luncheon - Creating a Truly Diverse Economy, it sets me thinking about the plan that my administration had put in place towards building a prosperous and economically vibrant Nigeria. I speak of the 3rd National Development Plan, 1975 - 80 that I launched at the National Hall, Tafawa Balewa Square on the morning of Saturday 29th March 1975. This is a little over 41 years ago.

The plan was audacious. We aimed to wage a 'war on want in the midst of plenty' for which the Federal Government resolved to provide necessary weapons 'in the form of peace, stability and just government.' The audacity of our programme, I believe, you will have more readily understand within the context of the quantum leap in capital expenditure from N5.3 billion (Second National Development Plan, 1970-74) to the projected over N30-N45 billion for the 1975-80 Plan. The N30-N45 billion consisted of an estimated N20-N30 billion aggregate investment by the Federal and State Governments and N10-N15 billion aggregate private sector investment.

Quite easily, you can see an early attempt to achieve robust public-private sector collaboration for national economic development. This is still desirable and should be encouraged. From what I can hear, the present government is attuned to it. Our plan was based on Agro-Allied industry and to build a base for Nigeria's industrial revolution by providing iron and steel, petrol chemical and LNG projects.

We projected that agriculture would continue to engage a large percentage of our population.

We planned more investment in education, health, industry, ports development as well as defence and security and general administrations. We made huge plans for roads with substantial increase from about 7,000 kilometers to approximately 30,000 kilometers. Then we set about encouraging the private sector to de-emphasise commerce and distribution in favour of direct production, investment in agriculture and other areas of economic development. Our overriding ambition was:

1. For Nigerians to take controlling height of their economy.
2. To share the benefits derived from projects under the 3rd National Development Plan with other African countries in the spirit of good neighbourliness, ECOWAS and African unity.

But as you all may know, it is said "dreams die fast." In our case, the dream died with the overthrow of my government four months after the Plan was enunciated and launched. The Plan was jettisoned by our successors, some of whom, incidentally, were part of the brains that conceptualised the programmes. This was not because of lack of conviction in the positive gains that would have accrued but because of a need to discredit a past regime. Remember the decimation of the public service and the plan. 41 years down the line, Nigeria is still grappling with the basic problems that we had sought to solve, which if achieved, would probably have placed us ahead of the Asian Tigers and others.

This is history.

Learning from this, what then do we need, to create a truly diverse economy that would help us to win the war against want in the midst of plenty? Yes, we had the oil to thank for utilising the resources to develop the economy and the wellbeing of the people and country.

I believe that the global fall in the prices of crude oil must have taught us a lesson that a mono-economy in contemporary times is an invitation to economic disaster. We need to revisit agriculture, particularly granting the strident calls to eat home grown food. We need to seriously reconsider national plans for the development of the infrastructure. The road networks must integrate all the geo-political zones to facilitate easy movement of people and goods. We must be concerned about policies and pronouncements that inhibit doing business in Nigeria and ensure cooperation and continuity for business and governance. We must pay attention to the power sector and ensure that it works. When we completed the Kainji Dam, the determination of my government was to positively change the economic future of Nigeria. Time has come for the national grid to be expanded to reach every nook and cranny of the country whilst State governments should aim at boosting rural electrification. When we promulgated the Indigenisation Decree in 1972, our objective was to fast track economic development in a manner that placed Nigerian citizens at the commanding heights of the economy. Oil and gas was excluded because we were careful to avoid situations that could make certain individuals to become too economically empowered to undermine governance and the national economy at a time that we were just recovering from the ravages of the Civil War. The truth of the matter is that, with modifications to take care of current realities, the 3rd National Development Plan is still implementable today, especially if all areas of economic development are taken into consideration as an organic whole. Economic development should be inclusive not exclusionary.

A key lesson that I believe we need to take on board, with specific reference to my government and national growth and development, is that continuity in governance is the path to change in Nigeria. I believe that members of the IoD, being largely private sector-driven and players, will better understand this when I speak of succession planning. Running a government is not much different from running a corporation. Once the goal or vision has been correctly identified, what is left is to maintain the strategic intent. There should be continuity in governance whereupon successor governments should be willing and able to take on board all progressive plans of their predecessors and run with the vision. It is not every occasion that the wheel needs to be reinvented, just for its sake. The good of the people and society must be paramount at all times. Every other thing is commonsensical.

By IoD Nigeria.



A JEDI FROM
PECKHAM

Fabien Soazandry



“ *Until* the lion
learns how *to*
write,
EVERY STORY
will
glorify
the hunter
African proverb ”



CULTURE





HACKETT

TRULY BRITISH, TRULY AUTHENTIC
MENS TAILORING AT ITS BEST



Interview with Philip Telesford, head tailor by **Joseph Farodoye**

Being Head Tailor at Hackett is obviously a big responsibility, how long have you been doing this?

I have been doing this for 15 years on and off but I have been at Hackett for 15 years. I started off as a sales person on the shop floor and worked my way up through training to becoming Head Tailor. It has taken a long time but I have arrived at a place that I really want to be.

What do you want clients to experience when they come in for a fitting at Hackett?

For me personally, it all starts with getting to know the customer - That's the primary objective before you start looking at products. It makes your job a hell of a lot easier. The first thing to do is to ask questions about the customer: his life, his job and maybe a little



about his private life - all done with utmost discretion. When you do this, it gives you an idea and a picture of what the customer would like. The reason we ask about their personal life, is because not only do we provide suiting, but we also do casualwear. So ultimately what we do is create an entire profile of the customer.

When it comes to the type of suits you sell at Hackett, what is the main or predominant look?

It's a very old British military look, very clean cut, very sharp, very classic and very English. When you see an English suit, you know it's an English suit. There are certain specifications that you have with an English suit that you would not have with a suit from another country. For example, in the width size, length of jacket etc. but also, the personal touches like the slant pockets and slightly higher waist trousers that give it a very specific type of elegance. A current trend shared with me by another tailor was that when it comes to the trouser, some are having them without belt loops or side adjusters - flat fronted trousers are quite a new thing.

In recent times Hackett has gone through a bit of a transformation, what is your current look?

The look right now is the international man. Hackett has evolved into a company somewhat similar to that of an English institution. It had a very particular look, the three buttoned suit with a centered vent - which is the marking of the old riding jacket - and higher waist trousers with the pleats and side adjusters.

Do you have African clients?

Very much so, we have quite a few. We get a lot of customers acknowledging Hackett as a top brand and I think since we have gone international, our quirkiness has attracted an



even wider audience. As African people, we are very much attracted to that vibrant colour and flair.

Thank you for explaining the traditional styles of Hackett, can you tell me a little more about your distinctly more colourful and vibrant new range?

We brought out our new range called the 'Mayfair' range and it is our more international, colourful and quirky range. It brings Hackett closer to the international market and is centred around the cut with a focus on making Hackett more fun, especially during the English summer. We use linens, luxury cottons, and design jackets in red, purple and green - These are the colours we do in the summer that the English guys love.

I would love to try something like this on, have you got something in my size?

Absolutely, we have a very special piece which has two weaves in there: the light blue weave and slight navy weave - It makes it a suit you can wear for occasions. This one here is a size 38 but because of the 'Mayfair' and the way it is cut, it is a slightly narrower and shorter jacket with a very nice fit. Sometimes people have to go up a size because of the way it fits, the pattern is quite close-fitted.

I love the way that it feels!

Yes- it feels at one with you!

It has been a truly amazing day, Hackett is definitely a brand that is synonymous with luxury and I have enjoyed the luxury experience.

[Watch the full video online](#)



AFRICAN FASHION

and the modern gentleman

Combining African heritage
with delicate French couture
Tina Lobondi forges a dynamic
synthesis of elegance and edginess.



It has been confirmed that African fashion is trending. Whether you live within the continent or in the diaspora, you cannot have missed the rise of the Ankara prints adopted by celebrities such as Beyoncé, Alicia Keys and Thandie Newton on the red carpet.

As some say, we live in a man's world so I wanted to take a look at what our men are wearing. The rise and popularity of African men's tailoring both within and outside the continent is a trend we can no longer escape.

From Lagos to Luanda, bespoke suits have been revamped for a new league of African gentlemen.

This sector of men's tailoring has always been dominated by the finest Italian labels such as Armani, Boss or my personal favourite Tom Ford but not forgetting all the famous names on Saville Row in London. They are the brands worn by the most successful male figures on our silver screens, newsfeeds and television making this a tight-knit circle to try and enter.

Africa is waiting on the day Idris Elba will become the new James Bond because we surely have the African luxury brands to match Bond's luxury cars and watches.

African fashion is on the rise but so are our men. To carry on talking about our Television stars, Empire protagonist Terrence Howard and Omari Hardwick starring in TV sensation "Power" are the men our designers are now looking to dress.

African luxury menswear labels have been growing on the down low building solid foundations of ethic and quality to their designs.

Tanzanian born designer Sheria Ngowi is redefining men's tailoring on the continent. His classic but perfectly fitted suits have been worn by Zambian president Edgar Lungu. He uses the finest material which puts the label on the same platform as Britain based legends such as Ozwald Boateng. Impeccable slim cuts, plaids and colourful materials are a fresh take on the classic bespoke suits which we could possibly compare with British

Tina's work has been published in Channel 4, Forbes Afrique, ITV, Marie-Claire and ELLE Magazine South-Africa, British Soap Awards, LOOK Magazine, OK Magazine, and BBC Africa.

label Hackett. In his most recent collection showcased at Mercedes Benz Fashion Week Johannesburg, Sheria received a well-deserved standing ovation. This young label has the potential to soar on an international level and compete with the biggest names in men's fashion. With over 100,000 followers on Instagram, it is clear that Africa agrees with his talent.

Another brand moving the continent is Laurence Airline. This Ivory Coast based label has been seen on RnB prodigy Usher and actor Eriq Ebouaney. Innovative shirts, cuts and eclectic suits are printed with vibrant colours representing the dynamism of Africa. The designer, Laurence Chauvin Buthaud, has created clothing for international jet setters. She also has a womenswear range which is equally fabulous and has been named a national treasure in her native country.

African designers' secret ingredients seem to be the focus on the quality and sense of style but most of all the passion they have for their craft. However, one question still resonates

in my mind: What else do African designers need to do in order to be recognised as key players on fashion platforms in the West? I wonder what would take African brands out of the "trending" phase and finally be recognised for dressing our presidents and movie stars. Could it simply be caused by the minimal PR and marketing? Does Africa need to create its own fashion network and Syndical Chamber of Haute Couture like in France? Well one thing is for certain: the continent certainly has hidden treasures in need of a bigger platform in order to shine outside social media.

Another sign of the growth of the industry are the male models such as Dave Kabamba who have been gracing the covers of GQ magazine in South Africa; they sport the best of men's tailoring created by African designers.

I am lucky to have seen these talents work from behind the scenes, their passion and will to succeed is a motivation for anyone with a dream to achieve and aim higher in their career.



ETHICAL FASHION INITIATIVE

Head of the Ethical Fashion Initiative of the International Trade Centre (ITC), an officer of the United Nations and passionate about Africa, Simone Cipriani oversees the promotion of trade and incubation of creative micro-enterprises within marginalised communities in Africa and Haiti.

Interview with **Joseph Farodoye**



What inspired you to create the Ethical Fashion Initiative?

The Ethical Fashion Initiative began in Kenya shortly after I met a lay missionary called Gino Filippini. Gino lived in a slum in Nairobi working with micro-producers and helping them to set up cooperatives. Gino and his work were a great inspiration to me as he was encouraging people to learn new skills and organise themselves to take control and improve their lives.

In addition, the artisanal and craft heritage to be found throughout the African continent was and continues to be a great inspiration to me. The wealth of artisans available in Africa reminded me of how the Italian fashion industry used to operate when I was a younger boy – with fashion originating from artisanal skills.

Describe your journey into the world of African fashion?

I met Kofi Ansah, a Ghanaian fashion designer, back in 2009 while I was already working to create the Ethical Fashion Initiative. Unfortunately, he passed away two years ago... Kofi helped me discover the reality of African design, the African fashion system, the local market of fashion (Kofi was a very good couturier). So I discovered the richness of African fashion and creativity. Kofi also invited me to discover the African fashion diaspora, living in Europe, the US and see their importance for the fashion market. This was a whole discovery which brought me to want to involve African designers in our programme.

In a few words can you outline the criteria a fashion brand must meet in order to be considered ethical?

That is a big question. There isn't a blueprint. I sometimes feel I don't want to focus only on ethics anymore because the issue today is about being responsible. And to be responsible and

ethical is to be sure that you respect the basic human rights of people in the supply chain. This requires that you pay people decently, there is no exploitation, no forced labour etc. Also that you adopt systems to do this and that you minimise impact on the environment. All these things require different strategies and different plans for every company. There isn't a blueprint but a general philosophy and then there are many tools to implement, from fair labour practices to paying a living wage, or carbon offsetting etc.

Why has there been such a global boom in African fashion?

Because there is a growing middle class which has always been fashion conscious but now has the means to support the growth of African fashion. This is also supported by the important international African diaspora. In addition, the international fashion sector has discovered that Africa has an identity in fashion so you have segments of the international fashion market which accepts and cherishes the presence of African designers.

What are some of the biggest challenges your organisation has faced?

Our main challenges have always been in organising the work of artisans to ensure it is productive, respects deadlines and they can access credit. Our aim is to create a supply chain out of scattered artisan groups and ensure it is coordinated one. This is a huge challenge wherever we work.

With the designers, the challenge is to enable them to have fair discussions with the

**EVERYONE SPEAKS ABOUT
SUPPORTING THE DESIGNERS BUT
NOBODY PROVIDES CAPITAL TO
INVEST IN THEIR BUSINESS**



world of the showrooms and the buyers as it is a world that is quite closed and currently is saturated with new small designers. Many of these small designers have to face the very challenging issue of capital availability – everyone speaks about supporting the designers but nobody provides capital to invest in their business. Having support to develop a clear idea of the business dimension of work would also be beneficial as the lack of clear and structured business plans hinders their development.

What are some of the leading ethical African fashion brands in the world?

I would suggest you check out the work of Sindiso Khumalo, AAKS and Studio 189. Visit facebook.com/sindisokhumalowomenswear, khumalomini.com, aaksonline.com and studiooneightynine.com.

What have been the most memorable milestones or highlights for the Ethical Fashion Initiative in 2015/2016?

Every new collection made with products from our artisan network is memorable as it represents the fruit of our work. A big achievement was the fact that the original social enterprise we helped create in Kenya has now become completely privatised after receiving investment from Kenyan impact investors who saw its potential. Our expansion in Haiti is also very exciting as well as our work in Ethiopia where we are building capacities to



Above, Simone Cipriani, head of the Ethical Fashion Initiative. Below some products by Vivienne Westwood and Odette e Odile.

make leather shoes and bags.

Organising big fashion shows like Generation Africa at Pitti Uomo have also been very important and with every event we can feel the growing excitement about African fashion design. The Generation Africa show was very important as we involved three asylum seekers who walked as models at the show and this has brought us to develop a programme working with migrants in Italy. This expansion of our work has been a big highlight in 2016.

In your expert opinion, what is the future of African fashion?

I don't know. I believe there is immense potential, unfortunately I don't have a crystal ball to see the exact pathway!

What is your vision for the Ethical Fashion Initiative?

To keep on growing as a supplier of authenticity, culture and love in the fashion industry for all brands – big, new, international, African, established, emerging – who want to put these three components into their work.



LDP

The inspirational chef
Lauren Von Der Pool
brings us the raw truth

Interview by *Uyai Akpan*

A graduate of Le Cordon Bleu Los Angeles and Paris Culinary School, Chef Lauren Von Der Pool has worked closely with renowned chefs and celebrity clients such as Wolfgang Puck, Alice Waters, Dr. Sebi, Patti LaBelle, Stevie Wonder, Common among many others. Her A-list celebrity events include The Oscars, Grammy's, Screen Actors Guild Awards, American Music Awards, Golden Globes, The Olympics, Wimbledon and many more.

Tell us about your journey, why did you become a raw vegan?

That's a good question, what made me become a raw vegan was that I grew up in a single parent home and I'd had very interesting circumstances growing up but I believe that when you're aligned with your purpose everything opens up for you. It was Washington DC, when Washington was the murder capital, drugs were really bad and as a young child and product of my environment



Lauren with celebrity client Common.

I was acting out, which caused me to get stabbed in my head and I almost died. There is a technique called tapping where you can tap your temples and other specific parts of your body and it activates you. So when I got stabbed in my head the pressure activated my pineal gland and I randomly became a completely different person. I initially purchased a book called 'Heal Thyself' by Queen Afia, I read it in one day and the next day honey, I was a raw foodist.

What inspired you to turn it into a profession?

Well I believe I have a hustler's spirit within me and I guess I get that from my daddy (laughs). I grew up in the hood where people were selling other things, they had \$5 dollar bags and \$10 dollar bags so I decided I would do a \$5 dollar pie and a \$10 dollar pie. I ended up volunteering at a health food store called Everlasting Life and it was a vegan raw store. Because I was a raw foodist, I worked in the produce section, so anything that was bruised or not pretty enough to sell they would give to me. I would take whatever they had and I would transform it into a pie, a salad or a juice and I would sell it right across the street from Everlasting Life in front of Howard University to the college students. It was actually at the

||
**IT'S ABOUT KNOWING
HOW TO BALANCE
EVERYTHING SO
THAT YOU CAN
EXPERIENCE LIFE**

||



health store that I met my sons' father but I ended up in an abusive relationship and I didn't always tell this part of the story because I was still healing from it. I'm now wanting to share it because there are girls out there who are teenage moms or even adults going through abuse and don't feel like they have the power to get out of it and I'm just grateful that I was able to break that cycle and can help others to do the same.

How has the raw vegan diet impacted the rest of your lifestyle?

It has changed everything.

This is what a lot of people don't understand, everything is energy but specifically because you are eating food, it becomes a part of you; it becomes a part of your energy field. So you want to eat high vibrational foods and I didn't initially realise I was doing this at 16. God just grabbed me out of the bunch and said 'Wait' (laughs) and as I started to eat differently, consuming all of these plants and different things, I simply became different. I became less angry, I became more aware and I was getting so much more oxygen to my brain that I was able to think better. I was an open channel to receive the light of God and to receive all of this creativity. And then I learned how to take the food to another level and raise the frequency through sound, through my thoughts and through my understanding of energy.

A lot of people and specifically women in today's society are so focused on what they look like externally and the superficial, with your book title being 'Eat Yourself Sexy' I find that you have tapped into the side of us that wants to be healthy but equally we want to look fantastic. How would you explain to someone that this type of lifestyle is actually sexy?

Well, just look at the results. Look at a person eating a standard American diet or a standard diet from whatever nation versus a person eating plants. 9 times out of 10 if the person eating plants is eating a proper balanced diet, you will see that reflected in their energy; it resonates through you because your inner universe is what reflects your outer universe. So if your insides are made up of beautiful things then you are naturally going to be beautiful and gorgeous on the outside but it's not just physical. The 'sexy' is really the activation of

all of the energy centres in your body. When you are really activated in your sexy, all of your chakras are open. Your second chakra which is all of that sensual, sexy energy is so on fire that you know...you didn't even mean to (laughs). You're just oozing it!

So tell me about the work that you do and what programs you run?

So I decided to start a non-profit called Von Der Pool Healthy Living Services which teaches children how to create gourmet food on a budget and it also teaches them how to grow their own food. In 2009, Michelle Obama found out about my work, she brought me on board to work with her on her Obesity Prevention Campaign where I was able to do a lot of things in the country. But I was already doing a lot of things in Kenya, Nigeria and South Africa with Venus and Serena Williams. Right now, I'm actually doing a storyboard album; it's a journey I get to take the listeners on. The name of the book is called "The Journey of Isis and The Super Rainbow Warriors" and the title of the album is "Isis"... It transformed me and I want to do this because I believe and know that music, whether good or bad, has the ability to change the vibrational frequency in your cells immediately. I am going to have an educational aspect to it so that people understand what is going on.

With such a personal intimate relationship with music and healing and the similar power or frequency through food, how did you find working with Academy Award winning recording artist Common?

Common is a king – He is on another level. He wanted to eat this way, he was already eating very healthily so he was already 'woke' and already aware of a lot and what I did was I came in and raised it to a higher level, specifically with food. How I work with my clients, whoever they are, is as a family and there is a certain love. Common has inspired me musically right now, both Common and Stevie Wonder are so encouraging for me. So we're working on our albums at the same time and we get to share daily when I see him and I'm cooking –he has studio sessions at Jim Henson, listening parties for Kanye and all these types of people and I'm doing the food for it all – so it's great.





Even with Venus and Serena Williams albeit a completely different industry, it leads back to the same source – The food they are eating is impacting their sport, is that right?

100% - When I first started working with them they had already made the decision, these are powerful women that were ready and wanted this. They say that when the student is ready, the teacher appears; so they were ready and that's why they attracted me into their lives. Within 6 months Serena Williams was world number one again, she went from being ranked 165 to being world number one and she became world number one in Qatar; all she did was change what she was eating.

You mentioned earlier being in countries like Kenya, South Africa and Nigeria – In Nigeria specifically one of the most popular dishes is stew. So they'll have maybe ground rice or amala for example with either a meat or fish stew which consists of blended tomatoes, onions, garlic, thyme, scotch bonnet and red bell peppers cooked in a pot with oil and simmered until cooked. As a raw vegan how would you recreate this dish?

Again all of these are beautiful ingredients so I would just make sure I'm using the right salts because you want to make sure you have magic

Above, raw delights presented in the most colourful way

in your food. I would use sea salts because it has 84 minerals that the body needs but doesn't get on a regular basis, black salt or celtic sea salt.

And the type of oil I would use would be extra virgin coconut oil and perhaps add the majority of it at the end so that it's not cooked down and you get all the goodness from it. Then I would cook it down as normal and instead of using a regular rice I would use a quinoa, black rice, red rice, sprouted rice or plantain. I'm Guyanese so I love what we would call provisions. You can do whatever you want to do, it's about freedom, you don't have to be in anybody's box – you get to experience life and understand whatever you're doing and the adverse consequences of it because it's all addition and subtraction. It's not that you can't experience life, it's about knowing how to balance everything so that you can experience life.

If you could sum up the impact and legacy you want to leave, what would it be in three words?

I would like to leave love and happiness beyond just healing but thriving. I would like to leave a completely transformed world with miracles. I want to activate certain parts of the world and build healing villages with pyramids and tree houses. So really at the core of it, I would say raising awareness of humanity.

 **Vitamix.**



RAWLIGION

Rawligion owner and ex-professional poker player John Tabatabai, delivers nutrient-dense food to improve the health and wellbeing of customers whilst exciting the senses. Rawligion sets out to transform the way we eat and challenge the current perceptions of a plant-based diet.

Interview with Joseph Farodoye



John this is an amazing place you have here, how did you get involved in raw food?

It's a similar story to most people, I became ill and luckily the doctors said I would never get better. I say luckily because it forced me to seek out other alternatives. Fortunately there were a few positive things that I tried but most of the significant changes I made was an overhaul in lifestyle. When I was younger I did a lot of things wrong as far as nutrition was concerned, so I changed my diet. Changing my diet was the most substantial thing that I did, but in addition to that I also changed my attitude. This was the first time it truly occurred to me to that every single thing that I eat becomes a part of me, it either adds to my health or takes it away.

How long ago was that?

That was roughly six years ago and I said to myself that if I ever got the opportunity, I would love to do something with healthy foods, if only to make it more accessible to people. Whether it was a juice bar or a plant based eatery then I would pursue it. Back then there were a lot more negative perceptions of raw food with mainstream establishments, or they simply weren't considered cool to go to by the general public - and that's when Rawligion was born.

How did you come up with the concept of a fast-casual plant-based restaurant?

Two years ago after much deliberation I finally decided to do this, it made a lot of sense and there was an awakening happening in London during that time. People want healthier foods; wheat free, gluten free, dairy free, flour free etc. but nobody knows where to get it. Making it at home takes forever, I know first-hand that you have to plan a few days in advance and people simply can't find the time these days. So I decided to create an environment where people want to meet, somewhere that's sexy and fun. I wanted to create a place where it doesn't matter what your beliefs are concerning food, it doesn't matter what diet you are currently consuming, the fact is eating a more plant-based diet is going to benefit you regardless of where you are on your particular journey and that's what Rawligion is about. Whether you like the food or not, there are drinks, desserts and chocolates - we use medicinal mushrooms, Ayurvedic herbs and so many different things. For example, in the desserts we have certain mood enhancing plants and things that help with lower back pain but you would never know because they still taste great.

What is the key to maintaining your success?

We have some amazing consultants and I've learnt that the way to create something incredible is to get experts, so that's what I did. We have experts in various fields such as raw chocolates, raw food and with our juices we work with an amazingly talented phytotherapist. These are the people who have helped to train our staff, create our menu and in addition they have created the training packages for us to learn from. With such a variety of herbs and plants it's virtually impossible to know how they all work and what their ingredients are, so we go through a long process to bring ourselves up to par.

When you combine specific foods, the effects can sometimes be adverse, so your training must be quite technical?

It certainly is (laughs). It's a fun process, we are learning so much on a daily basis and it's an incredible journey.

I have been blown away by your hospitality, your staff who are all amazing and the responses from your customers. One of the things I have found very unique here is that you have food which is gender specific?

There are certain hormones that are very specific to men and women that require different types of nourishment. For example we have one drink called Pretty in Pink it's aimed towards women and skin care so you'll find it has a lot of ingredients that promote blood flow to the skin like rose, aloe vera and pomegranate base. We have another drink called Raw Man and it's a very strong mix of pure caffeine extract mixed with some medicinal mushrooms and Ashwaganda, so it serves as a really powerful pre-workout drink.

Speaking of caffeine I am blown away by your coffee, I have never seen anything quite as beautiful and technical. Can you explain why it takes 12 hours to make?

It's a long process, just like our chocolate takes weeks to be consumer ready, our coffee is the same, it takes a long time. You have to wait for good things and that's what we as people tend to forget. In London everyone wants everything instantly and whilst our concept is 'grab and go' and items are ready to buy when you come in, our actual preparation processes take a long time. If you compare us to our competitors and our British competitors in particular, no-one is spending the kind of time that we are to ensure that you are consuming the absolute best of the best.

John, I can taste it in every bite, guys if you are anywhere near Goodge Street in London come down. This is not something you can purchase on the internet, it's something you really have to experience in person.

Watch the full video online



READ THE FULL
INTERVIEW ONLINE
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DO THE RIGHT *THING*

By Uyai Akpan



Most of us know what doing the right thing means, we simply need our own motivations for doing it. Sometimes sheer knowledge is not enough for us to embrace the changes we know are often needed to facilitate the results we say we want. We need something deeper, more meaningful and in some cases, unfortunately, more traumatic before we roll our sleeves up, put our big girl (or boy) pants on and face the initial upheaval that true change often brings.



It's never too late to change just like you're never too old to learn or too young to display wisdom. Whatever category you fall into, know this - you deserve the very best, when I say you, I'm talking about your mind, your body and your soul. Read great books find inspiring stories and feed your mind. Travel as much as you can, discover the world for yourself and feed your soul. Eat great food, 'living food', cuisine that imparts energy and life, genuinely nourish your body. Life is a gift and you are still unwrapping yours.

So be smart, look after yourself and make the most of this gift called life.

Stay Motivated And Do The Right Thing!

FULL S.T.E.A.M AHEAD

Our children and the Challenges of the Global Economy

BY JEFF BARNES



Our children face a perfect storm of challenges that will require new ideas, new skills and new solutions. The perfect storm is our need for a 21st century renewable energy economy; our need to upgrade or replace our crumbling infrastructure; the impact of globalization; a lack of young trade workers due to tracking our children to college rather than college and technical careers; the growth of the freelance economy and the trend of defunding public education at the local and state level.

Another challenge is that the baby boom generation born after World War II are reaching retirement age. While this should spell opportunities for younger tradesmen and women that will take their place, the fact is so many young people do not see the trades as a career option. Many of them do not have or take the opportunities in school or in their communities to acquire skills required by electricians, plumbers, mechanics, carpenters, chefs and policemen. As Sir Ken Robinson indicated in one of his most famous TedTalks, one of the biggest mistakes ever made was getting rid of the shop classes in high school. Another challenge is that competition is now global, especially in the information technology services due to communications and internet technologies and innovations.

Our children's skills acquisition will not happen overnight. We must make plans and changes for the long haul.

The table below outlines some changes we could make to our education systems to meet the challenges of the new work and career paradigms:

CHALLENGES	PROBABLE CAUSE	IMPACT	SOLUTION	EDUCATION PROGRAMS NEEDED
Climate Change	20th Century Oil, Coal and Gas Economy	- Limits manufacturing and production - Increases costs of doing business - High environmental impact	21st Century Renewable Energy Economy	Provide a solid STEAM Education - Build Professional skills - Teach Scientific Method and Life-Long Inquiry. - Enable 21st Century visionaries.
National, state and local economic, transportation and communication infrastructure failure	- Neglect. - Lack of political will. - Economic downturn - Baby Boomers (Skilled Tradesmen) retiring within the next ten years	- Difficult to compete globally - Trade deficits, - Manufacturing deficits - Stifling innovation - Stifling entrepreneurship	Rebuild old and create new competitive shared facilities (schools, bridges, roads, airports, etc.)	Provide a solid STEAM Education - Build Professional skills - Teach Scientific Method and Life-Long Inquiry. - Enable 21st Century visionaries.
- High School students are not graduating with marketable vocational skills - Abysmal graduation rate amongst college students - College students graduating without the skills for professional placement	- Doing away with Shop Classes in K-12 - K-12 Education programs promote college readiness at the expense of career readiness - Lack of curriculum standards that address the new challenges and prepares kids for success in college	- Not enough people with trade skills to do trade jobs - Over two million jobs that cannot be filled by our children because they lack the necessary trade skills - Importing Trade and professional workers	- New Schools construction with facilities that meet the need for the 21st century - New Standards based education that meets the needs of the 21st century. - Teacher development programs that will provide them with the skills to teach 21st century curriculum	Implement and promote Experiential Learning: - Build Craftsmen - Teach Project. Management Skills - Enable Mobile Freelancers - Project based learning - Build Entrepreneurs
- College debt increasing and limiting earning potential of new entrants into the workplace. - Many parents pay taxes and the private school fees to send their children to private academies. - Corporations not willing to invest in schools if they do not provide a useful labor force	The mistaken trend of marketing college as a means for individual development and the key to personal enrichment.	- Underprivileged tax payers not willing to pay to make other people's children rich. - Suburban tax payers not willing to pay bonds to build new K-12 schools. - Corporations will only fund something they think is innovative and solves the problems they face	- Focus on community - Show how a well-educated citizen benefits the entire community. - Explain that K-12 and college education is a strategic initiative to keep the country globally competitive	Focus on Service Learning - Build Citizens - Teach Stewardship - Enable Social Workers - Teach Place-Based Learning - Build internationally aware students through programs like International Baccalaureate.
Craft/Guild Companies replacing traditional companies: - UBER. - LYFT. - Design Crowd. - Airbnb. - High Number of Part-time workers.	Freelance Economy: (Craftsmen / Home-based / Mobile / Part-Time Workers). - Globalization and global competition enabled by innovations in telecommunications.	- Mobility work force. - Cottage Industry enablement. - Retirement packages minimal or non-existent. - Health Care costs off loaded to the individual.	- Recognize that the mobile economy is changing the workforce. - Provide shared merchant spaces and shared services for entrepreneurs, craftsmen and small business owners. - Create incubators for entrepreneurs. - Create internships and classes in running home based businesses.	Teach Critical Thinking - Build Problem Solvers - Teach SWOT Analysis and Solutions Management. - Enable Entrepreneurs. - Enable Mobiles Workers. - Build internationally aware students. - Teach information technology and data analysis literacy.

John Adams, the second American President once said, "I study war and politics, so that my children, can study math and science, so that their children, can study music and art!". He wasn't just thinking about his generation. He was thinking and planning for two generations ahead. I believe that our children have enormous opportunities ahead of them. Our job is to give them a 21st century education and the critical thinking skills they will need, to take advantage of those opportunities.

When I look a generation ahead, I see all of our children as,

Athletes at the Olympics • Engineers, rebuilding our bridges and tunnels • Scientists finding innovative ways to solve our energy problems • Programmers developing healthcare systems for our generation of retirees Architects blurring the lines between engineering and art.

And finally, I see them as leaders preparing the way for the generation that comes after them. We should work with our colleagues to develop and support the vision, the mission, and the goals that will give our children the education they need. More importantly we should support our teachers, our administrators, our parents, our community members, and other agencies that will help us to realize and fund these education goals.

HANNELI RUPERT

South African retailer Hanneli Rupert's chic, African selection of luxury, hand-crafted products and designs from her own ethical luxury handbag range Okapi. She has become one of the industry's most compelling advocates for ethical production and sourcing.

*Interview with **Joseph Farodoye***



So tell me about your journey, how did Okapi begin?

I wanted to give back; I wanted it to really be about people empowering themselves. I wanted to combine something from a creative side with business and I looked at what opportunities there were with locally sourced materials and manufacturing. I think there is an irony in the fact that so many of the world's greatest treasures from things like oil to game skins are sourced from Africa but then a lot of the value adds are abroad. And what I'm working towards doing is creating a truly authentic African luxury brand where the materials are locally sourced and the manufacturing is done locally and it's not overly inspired, as some of the local brands are, by international designs yet at the same time it's not completely just African/West prints slapped on like an iPad cover. Also with Okapi we wanted to work with organic materials and yet do it in a sustainable and ethical way.

So why the name Okapi and what would you say the brand is about?

The reason I named it Okapi is because it is actually the name of quite an unusual antelope; they are very rare and only found in the wild in one place which is the Ituri forest in the Congo and when it was discovered it got a nickname of being the African unicorn. This was because when they brought it back and showed it to the world it was at a time when people believed in fairies and mermaids and all of these exotic animals coming from around the world. And so a member of the zoological society in London, who I don't think had the skills to do taxidermy in the Congo at the time, could only bring back the hide and people accused him of sewing together the hide of a zebra, horse and giraffe and so they called it an African unicorn. And I liked that because of the parallels: I'm working with different pieces, I'm sourcing from all over Africa and I'm putting them all together. In a way I think there is this myth that luxury from Africa is unattainable and so I like this idea of Okapi being the African unicorn.



Tell me more about your brand: if you could summarise your brand in four words what would they be?

Sustainable, exotic, African and unique.

What influenced you to get into the luxury sector specifically?

It wasn't actually my primary goal to work within luxury and I think luxury is such a hard thing to decide. I set about creating this brand and I had certain credentials and objectives that I wasn't going to compromise on. I wanted the quality to be very good, the manufacturing processes to be ethical and I wanted to create pieces that people would value and keep for a long time. And in order to meet all of that criteria, they naturally became luxury pieces.

When did ethical production and sourcing become a focal point for you?

It was always built into the brand because when I started looking at what I wanted to do, it was focused on sustainable and ethical production, working with local artisans and making sure that all my skins were wrought in the correct way.

In terms of your work force, how many people in your company are from local environment?

I only employ one person plus myself from the UK, everyone else is in South Africa and they are all African. We're a small team. I also have Merchants of Long which is my multi-brand store and I stock brands from all over Africa. We have fashion but we also have a degree of home ware, perfumes etc. It's truly a concept store. I'm open to stocking anyone that is producing good quality merchandise that is interesting but manufactured in Africa with a similar ethos to Okapi.

You spoke at the International Herald Tribune Conference in Rome on the promise of Africa.

What potential do you see for African entrepreneurs?

Africa is so huge - I think Ethiopia have done a very good job because they have a monopoly of goatskin. So by banning the export of goatskin in its raw form they've managed to succeed in getting lots of manufacturers doing their finished end product locally and that has been wonderful for their economy. I think a lot of African countries could follow that. I think that given that we have so many available natural resources, it would be wonderful if we saw more international companies doing more locally. I think we are quite ahead of the curve in terms of sustainability and we could push that by looking at materials. For example, people no longer feel that they have to get purely a crocodile skin; there are so many organic materials that are really interesting and I think people in Africa are creating and coming up with practical solutions. I think that more time can be invested into how we can use our by-products and make interesting fashion or home ware pieces.

Do you have a manufacturing structure within South Africa as well?

I do, I combine so some of the pieces I outsource and some I do in-house.

What percentage would you say you outsource?

The majority of it, but I do have a very close relationship with the factories I do work with. For example, I am the only brand that I know of, definitely in South Africa but also internationally as well who works with the tanneries to produce a leather that specs it for what we want. Whereas most leather good brands will go to a trade show like Lineapelle and buy it, I work directly with the tanneries to achieve the exact finish that we want for the pieces.

And how do you think that translates into your product range?

It makes the pieces completely unique because you will never see that leather being used on any other product.

So a lot of your pieces are one-offs?

Exactly. All of the leather is unique so even if we do two pieces in the same colour, because I'm using exotic skins, the skins are different.

What has been the feedback you have received from the Western world on some of your African products?

We actually get mixed feedback, some people don't understand how using game skin can be sustainable, but some people do understand and we get very positive feedback.

If someone knew nothing about your brand and was perhaps a little confused about the game skin scenario, what would you say to that individual as to why it makes a huge difference that you are using game skin as opposed to the alternative?

I try to rationalise it by using an example of something they might find at home. So whilst some people might find it strange that we use ostrich for example, if they start to think of ostrich in the same way we would think of eating venison in England, they then realise that whilst it is an exotic animal it's not an endangered animal.

Within South Africa what challenges would you say South African entrepreneurs would have to overcome particularly in your industry?

Sometimes it may feel like you're fighting an uphill battle and this doesn't go for the whole of Africa but in South Africa there are issues of corruption and that is very difficult to deal with.

How have you managed to overcome that yourself?

Everybody is so connected through the internet nowadays and people travel so much that the best way to go about that is to become an international brand and not try to localise things too much. It's about diversifying as much as possible.

What advice would you give to a brand wanting to get involved in ethical manufacturing and sourcing?

I would say build your brand on what you're inspired by and do it in an ethical and sustainable way. However, don't think that you can have sustainability as the core of the brand, it should just be one of the criteria that you meet.

If you had a crystal ball and could predict where Okapi will be in five years, what would you like to see?

I would like to see Okapi have more presence in the US and Asia. And I'd like to see us being able to go work with and more collaborations with craft groups and introduce new product lines bringing in more home ware and design elements.

In three words can you sum up the legacy you would like the Okapi brand to leave for yourself and for Africa?

I would say timeless, exotic quality.

AFRICAN CULTURE, AFRICAN SPIRIT

INFLUENCE OF THE DRUM PART ONE

By Denice Refael



Africa is a continent of such enormous land mass but along with this comes a huge Nubian population filled with diversity, rich culture and traditions. Traditions of art, music, dance and song, all adopted and transformed to fit many modern cultures worldwide; countries like Brazil, Cuba, Trinidad and Tobago, Haiti, Dominican Republic, and the United States of America to name a few. How is this? Let's take the drum, an instrument so simple but yet so complex, that it's message is used and understood within every language, without translation.

The drum is known to have originated from Western Africa by the Mandinka tribe. The Mandinka tribe were under the rule of King Sundiata, who ruled over most of West Africa including Senegal, Mali, Guinea, Gambia, Burkina Faso, and Cote d'Ivoire. This unity of rule was important in the spread of the drum but it was not the major contributing factor for the wide spread use and familiarization of the drum. The Mandinka were known to have casts and each cast played a major role in the functionality of the community. The Numu cast were known as blacksmiths who were nomadic in nature. With their travels they carried the djembe drum. >





The djembe drum is made from the strongest trees in Africa. Before the trees are taken down, the workers perform a prayer: of thankfulness to God, for the blessings of nature and for the restoration and regrowth of those resources. Once the tree is timbered, it is divided into equal pieces and the bark hallowed and hand carved to perfection. It is then topped with rawhide, preferably goat skin. The djembe drum

normally ranges from 23 to 25 inches in height, 12 to 15 inches in diameter and between 11 to 28 pounds in weight but each drum will resonate its own unique sound. The djembe changed, becoming versatile with it travels, fitting within each individual culture while still holding onto the true soul of the djembe. This versatility is seen in the Fulla Djembe from Guinea, the Barkarabu from Senegal and the Tama drum from Gambia, all used for making the sounds that dictate the events of their communities: events in the involvement of marriage, baptisms, funerals, or basic work such as ploughing and harvesting. In my opinion, this may explain the resilience and strength of the African slave that somehow resonated from the drum. That powerful sound drumming and moving their spirits, making songs of hope filled with soul and providing strength within themselves to work as one. Giving one another life, almost like the sound of the heartbeat that indicates life: dun dun...dun dun!

The drum went further than domestic celebration: it flowed like the blood in your veins, it touched every aspect of life and it even went to war. In Africa the tribes would use the drum in endemic warfare. In endemic warfare, there was a continual state of low threshold warfare: this type of warfare was practiced in tribal societies, practiced in African societies, where it became ritual, common place, and the defining way to resolve conflicts. The powerful tribe of the Zulu practiced this type of warfare for some time until colonialism. The fighting ritual was known as the Indlamu. This technique began with each warrior lifting one foot over his head and then bringing it to the ground in a forceful manner to the sound of the drum beat. The movements were skillful but aggressive, tending to combine dancing with martial arts. Today, in Senegal there's a sport, somewhat like martial arts and wrestling combined, known as Laamb wrestling.

Laamb wrestling has been practiced in Senegal, its roots from the Serer people. For centuries, Laamb

wrestling began as a way to honor the village and as a way for men to court wives. However, it later became a leisurely activity for many farmers and fisherman. It was not until 1960, upon Senegal winning independence from France, that it soon gained momentum and recognition as a sport. It is now the favorite past time of the African region, to the point that it has surpassed soccer as the most popular sport. If you ever have the opportunity to attend or view a Laamb match, you will notice how the movements resemble dance, wrestling, and martial arts. Speaking of dance, most countries have adopted or applied endemic warfare into their culture by way of Hip Hop.

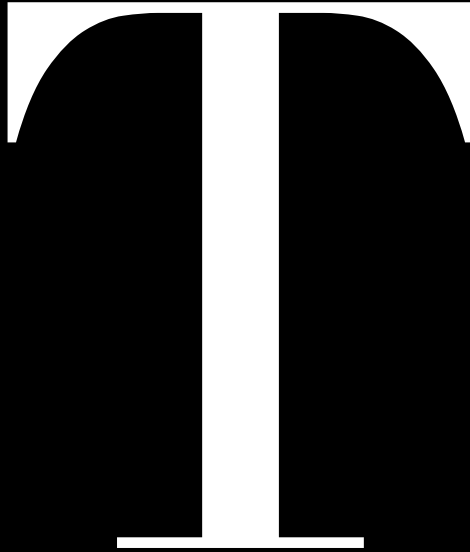


Hip Hop began in the United States in the 1970s, on the streets of South Bronx, New York and within the black/native and Latino communities. Hip Hop is a combination of lyrical rhymes capturing one's experiences, joys, defeats, or triumphs. It frequently focused on political climates of the time, on stance of actions, or it could just simply allow one to reflect.

Beats flowing, pulsating, and moving you and then... the lyricist would begin. The lyricist, better known in the hip hop world as a rapper, begins to perform with a battle of words; words that were direct and cutting but yet poetic in deliverance. This excitement builds and next there could be breaking or what we now call breakdancing. Breaking was part of hip hop; therefore, it arrived on the scene with rapping. Breaking was very popular with the youth and many of the gangs. These gangs would often resort to breaking versus physical conflict. Some movements so similar to those of our ancestors and some movements which would make the ancestors proud; whether they were those of the Zulu, the nomadic Mursi of tribe of Ethiopia, the Maasi of Kenya or the Bendi of Nigeria ancestry. By now, this has to sound familiar... right, endemic warfare. Again, it merges with the beat of the mighty and forever present ancestral drum. An instrument allowing a show of strength without violence, allowing freedom of expression through dance, and emotion through song. It communicates and connects with each of us; somehow it talks to us on a spiritual level bringing, unity, resilience, happiness...Us.

All we have to do is just listen and hear the message, then we can understand the beat...dun dun, dun dun becoming one.

Close your eyes, I can feel it, can you....
dun dun, dun dun.



TRAVEL



MARIA PAJARES

Interview with **Mehetabel Merid**



How did you get into this industry?

I was born into the industry so there was no escaping! My whole family work in the hospitality industry and I lived in a hotel when I was young. Once you're hooked, there's no escaping. The variety of people you meet and places you travel to make this an incredible industry to work in.

What is your inspiration?

People are my inspiration. My father, a hotelier, is a great role model and mentor. In addition, all the people I've worked for or alongside continue to inspire me, particularly those that aren't afraid to question the norm and do things differently if there's a good reason for doing so.

What are some of the most important or essential elements a luxury resort should have?

Obviously it's assumed that the product and services of a luxury resort will be of the highest possible quality. Putting this to one side then, for me there are two elements that make one luxury resort stand apart from another. The first is the extra touches – this could be anything from something as simple as full size amenities in the bathrooms instead of the more generic smaller bottles to exceptional experiences to choose from. The second and most important element of a luxury resort is the staff – it's always people that make the difference. The right balance between being friendly and professional is hard to strike, and the hotels that get it just right really stand out.

Describe the potential of Africa as a tourist destination for the future?

Africa is really exciting right now. We can always tell with our business (a luxury hotel Sales and PR agency) which destinations are becoming more popular by the number of enquiries we receive for PR and Sales representation. Of late, there's been a lot coming from Africa. We currently work with 6 hotel clients in Africa located in South Africa, Morocco, Nigeria, Rwanda, Uganda and Zanzibar.

***You have been in this industry for a long time and seen changes within luxury travel, have you noticed any particular trends this year either in what the luxury traveler wants or what your clients are offering?***

Everyone, no matter how wealthy they are, is looking for value for money now. Nobody wants to feel that they are being taken advantage of. Clients are looking for more and more costs to be included in their room rate rather than being added on as extras; even if it inevitably makes the room rate more expensive. This way there are no horrible surprises. Luxury travelers are looking for more choice and flexibility when they stay away from home – for example not being forced to eat at particular times because that's when the restaurants are open. And finally experiences that you can't get at home – this could be educational, cultural, adventurous etc. Fitness and spa are changing too – customers are looking more and more for a wellness experience rather than just getting fit or being pampered.

What are some of the "must know about" travel destinations in Africa for luxury travellers?

I am not an Africa specialist but from what we have seen at Mason Rose, I would say, Zanzibar, safe but still relatively undiscovered. Johannesburg, generally seen as the poor relation to Cape Town from a leisure perspective but it shouldn't be overlooked – there are some vibrant new areas cropping up like Maboneng which has a young, cultural and entrepreneurial spirit to it. Lagos, Nigeria, the largest city in Africa and economically becoming ever more significant.





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ROYAL MANSOUR MARRAKECH



THE MASLOW JOHANNESBURG



THE SAXON HOTEL VILLAS & SPA, JOHANNESBURG



FEDERAL PALACE LAGOS

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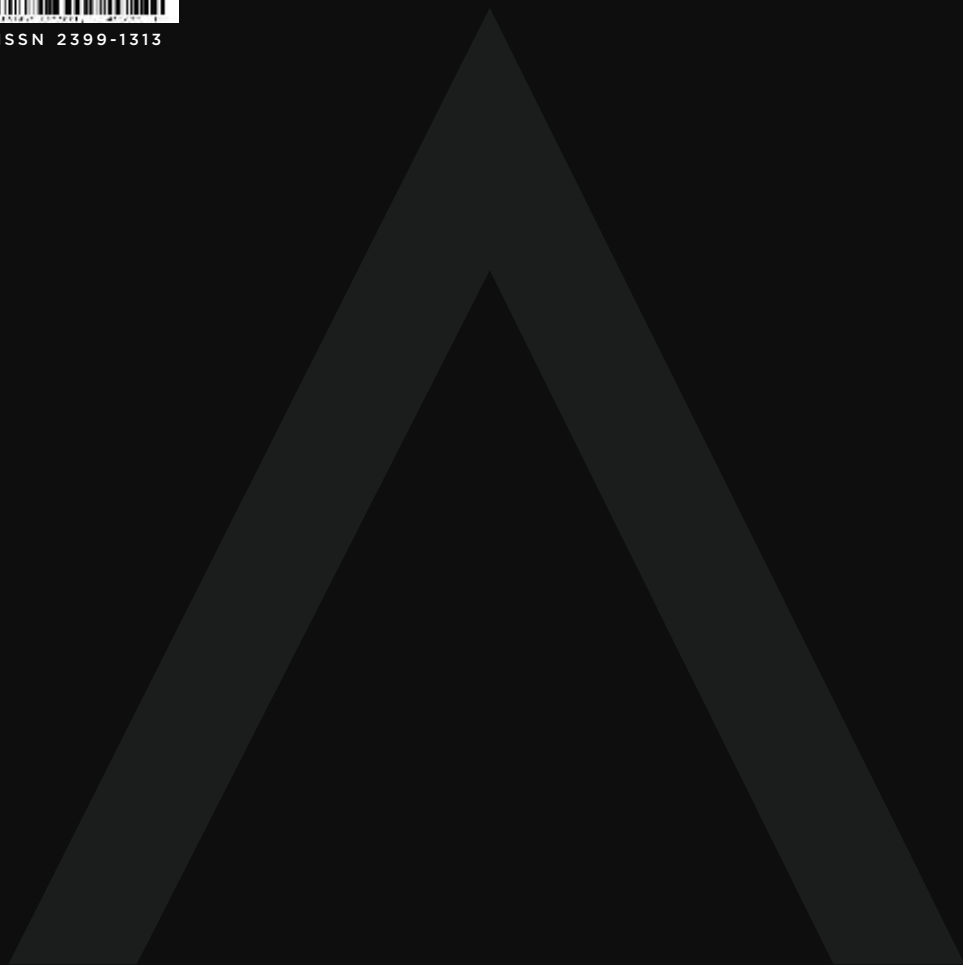
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